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Urban Planning | Community Development | Affordable Housing

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Genesee Transportation Council
Rochester, NY

Dear Hiring Committee:

I am writing to apply for the Transportation Planner, Community Planning position with the Genesee Transportation Council. I hold a Master of Urban Planning from the University at Buffalo and bring more than five years of professional experience across planning-adjacent fields, including community development, affordable housing development, project and program management, community outreach, research, and coordination with public agencies and community partners. Together with my graduate transportation planning education, this experience has developed many of the analytical, problem-solving, communication, and project-management skills GTC identifies for this position.

My graduate planning work provides a direct foundation for the transportation responsibilities of the role. I completed Strategic Urban Transportation Planning along with coursework in Land Use & Physical Planning, Urban Design, Environmental Planning & Policy, GIS Applications, and Research Methods in Planning. In the Northeast Greenway Initiative graduate studio, commissioned by the University District Community Development Corporation, I co-authored a Rail-to-Trail planning study that was subsequently used to help activate the Northeast Greenway Rail Trail. Our work examined bicycle and pedestrian access, neighborhood and regional connectivity, transit connections, intersection challenges, route alternatives, accessibility, and the relationship between transportation and surrounding land uses. I also studied NACTO guidance as part of my transportation planning education.

I am particularly interested in GTC's role as the MPO for a nine-county region that includes the Rochester metropolitan area as well as smaller cities, towns, villages, and rural communities. My planning studies and professional work have given me an understanding of how transportation needs and barriers differ across urban and rural settings, including access to employment and essential services, first- and last-mile connections, pedestrian and bicycle infrastructure, transit availability, land-use patterns, and the greater transportation challenges faced by people who do not have reliable access to a car. I would welcome the opportunity to apply that regional perspective to corridor, neighborhood, active transportation, multimodal, and transit planning throughout the Genesee-Finger Lakes region.

Community engagement is also central to my background. In family services, homeless outreach, and neighborhood-based affordable housing development, I have worked directly with residents, municipalities and government agencies, community organizations, healthcare and housing providers, funders, contractors, and other partners. These roles have required me to identify problems, evaluate options, coordinate people with different priorities, communicate technical or program information clearly, facilitate meetings and workshops, and keep the needs of diverse communities central to implementation.

My project management experience further aligns with GTC's work. I have experience with RFP and proposal development, procurement and contracts, consultant and contractor coordination, budget and schedule management, grant and regulatory compliance, research and data analysis, review of project materials, reporting, and presentations. While my professional background has not been within an MPO, I bring relevant planning education, transferable professional experience, knowledge of regional transportation issues, and a strong record of working across organizations and with the public.

Thank you for considering my application. I would welcome the opportunity to discuss how my planning education, community outreach experience, regional perspective, and project management background could contribute to GTC's community transportation planning work.

Sincerely,

Rachel S. Bailey, M.U.P.